

Chromosomes Rodlike structures containing genes occurring in pairs within the nucleus of every cell. Human cells each contain 23 pairs.

Colostrum A kind of milk, rich in proteins, formed and secreted by the breasts in late pregnancy and gradually changing to mature milk.

Corpus luteum A glandular mass that forms in the ovary after fertilization. It produces progesterone, which helps form the placenta, and is active for the first 14 weeks of pregnancy.

Crowning The moment when the baby's head appears in the vagina and does not slip back again.

CVS See [Chorionic villus sampling](#).

Dilation Progressive opening of the cervix caused by uterine contractions.

Dizygotic See [Twins](#).

Doppler A method of using ultrasound vibrations to listen to the fetal heart.

Doula A professional labor assistant who provides support during childbirth.

EDD The estimated date of delivery.

Edema Swelling caused by retention of excess fluid in your body.

EEG See [Electroencephalogram](#).

Electroencephalogram (EEG) A test where electrodes are placed on the scalp to record the electrical activity of the brain.

Electronic fetal monitor An electronic monitor that is used to measure the progress of the mother's contractions and the baby's heartbeat during labor.

Embryo The developing organism from about the 10th day after fertilization until about the 12th week of pregnancy, when it is termed a fetus.

Engorgement The congestion of the breasts with milk or edema. If long periods are left between feedings, or the baby is not well latched on, painful engorgement can occur.

Episiotomy A surgical incision of the perineum to enlarge the opening of the vagina.

Estrogen A hormone produced by the ovary, and by the placenta in pregnancy.

External version (External cephalic version, or ECV). The manipulation by gentle pressure on the fetus into the cephalic position. This may be done by an ob at the end of pregnancy if the baby is breech or transverse.

Fetal distress A shortage in the flow of oxygen to the fetus, which can arise from numerous causes.

Fetus The developing child in the uterus, from the end of the embryonic stage around 12 weeks, until the birth.

Hormone A chemical messenger in the blood that stimulates various organs to carry out specific actions.

Human chorionic gonadotropin (hCG) A hormone produced by early embryos and later the placenta, which is detected in urine pregnancy tests.

HypnoBirthing A type of self-hypnosis using visualization and breathing techniques to achieve a deep state of relaxation during labor.

Hypotension Low blood pressure.

Identical twins See [Twins](#).